

AMAZON RAINFOREST

One of the most productive ecoregions on Earth

The Amazon is the world's largest tropical rainforest, covering 2.1 million sq miles (5.5 million sq km) of the drainage basin fed by the long and winding river that shares its name. The rainforest is among the most productive and biodiverse ecoregions on the planet, containing around 10 percent of all the world's known species and potentially many more that have yet to be discovered. The huge variety of plants provides a multitude of habitats and food for a myriad of different animal species. It is also important because it stores large amounts of carbon—110–154 billion tons (100–140 billion metric tons)—that would otherwise be in the atmosphere.

Life among the layers

Overwhelmingly green to look at, with bright flashes of color from flowers, fruit, monkeys, and birds, the rainforest consists of several different layers. The tallest trees project above the main rainforest canopy, which itself forms the middle layer. This layer is the most diverse, and beneath it lie the understory and then ground level, where much less light—and moisture—penetrates. The lush jungle foliage slows the speed of rain falling to the forest floor, where deep soil and decaying plant matter act like a sponge, holding water and slowly releasing it to streams and rivers.

Vegetation can be so thick, **rain** may take **10 minutes** to reach the ground



AGOUTI

SEED DISPERSER

The agouti is one of the few animals able to gnaw through the tough fruit of the Brazil nut to release its seeds. When fruits are abundant, it hoards surplus seeds for later, often far from the parent tree, where they may be forgotten about and grow into new trees.

The world's largest tropical rainforest

Been in existence for 55 million years

LIVING RAFT

Many parts of the Amazon rainforest flood periodically, presenting a problem for creatures that nest underground such as fire ants. During floods, members of the ant colony form a raft out of their own bodies on which eggs, larvae, and queen are kept safe and dry.

FIRE ANTS

Covers 40% of South America

PARA RUBBER TREE

RUBBER BOOM

The bark of the Para rubber tree is cut to release milky latex sap. This sap is used to make products such as rubber boots and latex gloves, or is chemically treated to produce tougher items such as tires.